

DIGITALAIKART · PREMIUM DIGITAL EDITION

THE DEFENCE OFFICER 2027

HANDBOOK

NDA · CDS · AFCAT · THE SSB INTERVIEW

India's complete guide to the officer entry exams of 2027
and the five-day SSB that decides who wears the stars.

EVERY DATE AND RULE VERIFIED FROM OFFICIAL SOURCES

UPSC 2027 calendar · Ministry of Defence notifications · Indian Air Force AFCAT
Exam pattern, eligibility, SSB process and 15 OLQs - decoded in plain English.

Edition: October 2026

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ABOUT THIS EDITION

Read this page first

This handbook is an independent, reader-friendly guide to the officer entry examinations conducted in India for the National Defence Academy, the Combined Defence Services and the Indian Air Force's AFCAT, together with the Services Selection Board (SSB) interview that follows the written tests.

Every date, eligibility rule, exam pattern, marking scheme and process detail in this book has been taken from official or primary sources and checked against them. The main sources are the UPSC Annual Calendar 2027 (released 20 May 2026), the UPSC NDA and CDS notices of examination, the Ministry of Defence notification for the Combined Defence Services Examination, the Indian Air Force AFCAT entry pages, and the SSB and medical standards published by the Ministry of Defence. The edition date is October 2026.

A note on dates and eligibility

UPSC publishes exact birth-date windows, not a vague age range, and it publishes them with each cycle's notification. Where a 2027 window is not yet notified, this book states the last confirmed window and the rule UPSC applies, and tells you exactly where to confirm it on notification day.

Notifications, vacancies and dates are liable to change. Always treat the official notification for your own cycle as the final word. This book tells you what to look for and where.

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How to use this book: if you are a Class 11 or 12 student, start with Part 2 (NDA). If you have finished your degree, start with Part 3 (CDS) or Part 4 (AFCAT). Everyone should then read Part 5 onwards, because the SSB is the stage most aspirants underestimate - and the stage that carries as many marks as the entire written exam for the NDA.

PART 1

The officer entry map: every route to a commission

India commissions officers through a handful of entry routes, and almost every one of them uses the same two-stage filter: a written examination followed by the Services Selection Board. Knowing which door is yours - today - is the single most useful decision you can make.

There are two big families of entry. The first is the UPSC-conducted written exams: NDA (for school leavers) and CDS (for graduates). The second is the single-service routes run by the services themselves: AFCAT for the Air Force, TES and other technical entries for the Army and Navy, and the NCC Special Entry. This book covers the three routes that attract the largest number of applicants - NDA, CDS and AFCAT - plus the SSB that all of them lead to.

The main officer entry routes in 2027

Entry	Who it is for	Conducted by	Stage after written
NDA & NA	Class 12 passed or appearing, roughly 16.5-19.5 yrs	UPSC	SSB (5 days) + medical
CDS	Graduates / final-year students	UPSC	SSB (5 days) + medical
AFCAT	Graduates, Air Force branches	Indian Air Force	AFSB (5 days) + medical
TES / Technical	Class 12 PCM, engineering-minded	Army / Navy	SSB + medical
NCC Special Entry	NCC 'C' certificate holders (Army)	Army via UPSC/SSB	SSB + medical

The written exams differ in content and difficulty, but the SSB is common to all of them and carries equal or greater weight. For the NDA, the written exam is 900 marks and the SSB is another 900 - a 50-50 split. A candidate who tops the written but fails the SSB is not selected, and a candidate who clears the written by a modest margin can still win a place on the strength of the SSB. That is why half of this book is about the SSB.

Your 2027 calendar at a glance

Exam	Notification	Apply by	Written exam
NDA & NA (I) 2027	2 Dec 2026	22 Dec 2026	11 Apr 2027 (Sun)
CDS (I) 2027	2 Dec 2026	22 Dec 2026	11 Apr 2027 (Sun)
NDA & NA (II) 2027	12 May 2027	1 Jun 2027	19 Sep 2027 (Sun)
CDS (II) 2027	12 May 2027	1 Jun 2027	19 Sep 2027 (Sun)
AFCAT 01/2027	Expected Nov 2026	Expected Nov-Dec 2026	Expected late Jan 2027

The NDA and CDS dates above are fixed in UPSC's Annual Calendar 2027. The AFCAT dates follow the pattern of recent cycles and are marked as expected until the Air Force issues the notification. Notice the pattern: the two UPSC exams share a notification date, and the written exams fall on the same day.

Why this window matters

Today is early October 2026. The NDA (I) and CDS (I) 2027 notifications arrive in about eight weeks, on 2 December. The exams are on 11 April 2027 - roughly six months away.

That is exactly enough time to build the written score and, more importantly, to start becoming the person the SSB is looking for. Aspirants who begin serious preparation in October consistently outperform those who begin in January.

PART 2

The NDA & NA Examination 2027, decoded

The National Defence Academy and Naval Academy Examination is UPSC's gateway for school leavers into the officer cadre of the Army, Navy and Air Force. It is run twice a year. It is also, by any measure, one of the most competitive examinations in the country.

900 Written marks	900 SSB marks	394 Seats (2026 cycle)	2 Exams a year
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The official 2027 dates

UPSC released its Annual Calendar for 2027 on 20 May 2026. For the NDA it lists two cycles:

Cycle	Notification	Last date to apply	Exam date	Course begins
NDA & NA (I) 2027	2 Dec 2026	22 Dec 2026	11 Apr 2027 (Sun)	Early 2028
NDA & NA (II) 2027	12 May 2027	1 Jun 2027	19 Sep 2027 (Sun)	Mid 2028

UPSC's own footnote applies: the dates of notification, commencement and duration of examinations are liable to alteration if circumstances so warrant. In practice the NDA and CDS dates in the annual calendar have been reliable, and the notification itself confirms them.

Eligibility: what actually decides your form

Most NDA rejections happen before the exam, on eligibility. Read this section as a checklist, not as background.

Age: a birth-date window, not a range

UPSC does not say '16.5 to 19.5 years'. It prints two dates and you must have been born between them. For the NDA & NA (II) 2026 cycle the window was: born not earlier than 1 January 2008 and not later than 1 January 2011 - which works out to roughly 16.5 to 19.5 years. The exact window for NDA (I) 2027 is published with the notification on 2 December 2026. Your date of birth is taken only from your Class 10 (Matriculation or equivalent) certificate; horoscopes, affidavits and municipal birth extracts are not accepted.

Marital status

Only unmarried male and female candidates may apply, and a candidate must undertake not to marry until training is complete. This is a hard rule, not a preference.

Gender

Following the Supreme Court's 2021 interim order, unmarried women are eligible for the NDA on the same terms as men. In each 2026 cycle, 24 of the 394 seats were reserved for women.

Education, by wing

Wing	Educational requirement
Army Wing	Class 12 pass (any stream) of a recognised board
Navy Wing and Air Force Wing	Class 12 with Physics, Chemistry and Mathematics (PCM)
Naval Academy 10+2 Cadet Entry	Class 12 with Physics and Mathematics

Candidates appearing in Class 12 can apply, provided they can produce proof of passing at the time the Academy requires it.

Nationality and fee

A candidate must be a citizen of India, or a subject of Nepal, or a person of Indian origin who has migrated from certain listed countries with the intention of settling in India. The application fee is Rs. 100, paid online. Scheduled Caste, Scheduled Tribe and female candidates are exempt, as are the wards of serving or ex-JCOs/NCOs/ORs who are themselves studying in a Military or Sainik School. There is no fee exemption for OBC or EWS candidates.

The exam pattern and the marking that punishes guessing

The written exam is two papers sat on the same day, both objective, both two and a half hours, for 900 marks. Then the SSB adds another 900. The grand total is 1800.

Paper	Subject	Questions	Marks	Duration	Per correct	Per wrong
Paper I	Mathematics	120	300	2 hr 30 min	+2.5	-0.83
Paper II	General Ability Test	150	600	2 hr 30 min	+4.0	-1.33
Total	Written exam	270	900	5 hours		

The negative marking is exactly one-third of a question's value, and there is no penalty for leaving a question blank. That single fact should shape how you attempt the paper. In Mathematics, every three wrong answers erase the value of one correct answer. In the GAT, where each question is worth 4 marks, three wrong answers erase 4 marks. The safe policy is to attempt only questions you are at least 70-80 per cent confident about, and to leave the rest blank without regret.

The GAT is worth twice the Maths paper

The General Ability Test carries 600 of the 900 written marks - twice the Mathematics paper. Inside the GAT, Part A (English) is 200 marks and Part B (General Knowledge) is 400 marks. Many aspirants over-invest in Maths because it feels harder, and under-invest in the GAT, which actually decides most results. The 400-mark General Knowledge section alone outweighs the entire Maths paper.

The syllabus, mapped

The Mathematics paper is set at the Class 11-12 level. The GAT's General Knowledge is drawn mostly from Classes 6 to 12.

Mathematics

- **Algebra** - sets and Venn diagrams, complex numbers, binary system, progressions, quadratic equations, permutations and combinations, binomial theorem, logarithms.
- **Matrices and Determinants** - types of matrices, operations, determinant and its properties, solution of linear equations by Cramer's rule and the matrix method.
- **Trigonometry** - angles, ratios and identities, sum and difference formulae, multiple and sub-multiple angles, heights and distances, properties of triangles.
- **Analytical Geometry (2D and 3D)** - straight lines, circles, conic sections, planes.
- **Differential and Integral Calculus** - limits, derivatives, applications, integration by substitution and parts, definite integrals and areas, first-order differential equations.
- **Vector Algebra** - dot and cross products, work done, moment of a force.

- **Statistics and Probability** - mean, median, mode, variance, standard deviation, correlation, elementary probability, Bayes' theorem, binomial distribution.

General Ability Test - Part A (English, 200 marks)

Grammar and usage, vocabulary, comprehension, cohesion in extended text, spotting errors, fill in the blanks and synonyms/antonyms. This section rewards reading and practice more than memorisation.

General Ability Test - Part B (General Knowledge, 400 marks)

- **Physics** - states of matter, motion, sound, light, heat, electricity and magnetism, simple machines, telescopes and microscopes.
- **Chemistry** - physical and chemical changes, elements and compounds, properties of air and water, structure of the atom, valency.
- **General Science** - living and non-living matter, cells and tissues, the human body, common epidemics, the solar system, achievements of eminent scientists.
- **History** - a broad survey of Indian history with emphasis on culture and civilisation, and the freedom movement.
- **Geography** - the earth, its shape and movements, climate, the oceans, continents, regional geography of India and the world.
- **Current Events** - national and international affairs, and events of the recent past.

Vacancies and the competition, in plain numbers

In both 2026 cycles UPSC advertised 394 vacancies. Here is the breakdown of a recent cycle, which shows both how the seats are split and how small the female allocation has been:

Wing / Academy	Male	Female	Total
NDA - Army Wing	198	10	208
NDA - Navy Wing	37	5	42
NDA - Air Force Wing (Flying)	90	2	92
Air Force - Ground Duties (Technical)	16	2	18
Air Force - Ground Duties (Non-Technical)	8	2	10
Naval Academy 10+2 Cadet Entry	21	3	24
Total	370	24	394

UPSC does not publish how many candidates apply. Coaching institutions and the press put the figure between roughly 2.5 lakh and over 5 lakh per cycle, and there is no official number to settle it. What is beyond dispute is the ratio: a few hundred seats against lakhs of aspirants. Treat every estimate of 'your chances' with caution, and treat preparation as the only variable you control.

PART 3

The CDS Examination 2027, decoded

The Combined Defence Services Examination is UPSC's graduate-entry route into the officer cadre. It is the natural next step for anyone who missed the NDA age window or discovered the defence dream during college.

The official 2027 dates

Cycle	Notification	Last date to apply	Exam date
CDS (I) 2027	2 Dec 2026	22 Dec 2026	11 Apr 2027 (Sun)
CDS (II) 2027	12 May 2027	1 Jun 2027	19 Sep 2027 (Sun)

The CDS shares its notification and exam dates with the NDA. A candidate who is eligible for both can, in principle, sit both papers - but check the rules for each, because eligibility differs sharply.

Four academies, four different exams

The single most important thing to understand about the CDS is that your choice of academy changes both your eligibility and your exam. There are four destinations:

Academy	Service and nature	Maths paper?
IMA, Dehradun	Army, permanent commission	Yes
INA, Ezhimala	Navy	Yes
AFA, Hyderabad	Air Force	Yes
OTA, Chennai	Army, short service commission	No

OTA candidates sit only English and General Knowledge. IMA, INA and AFA candidates sit those two plus Elementary Mathematics. Choosing OTA is a legitimate strategy for a candidate whose mathematics is weak - but it commits you to a short service commission.

Eligibility by academy

The Ministry of Defence sets age, marital status and educational rules separately for each academy. The framework below is drawn from the CDS (II) 2026 notification; your own cycle's notification will print fresh birth-date windows.

Academy	Age band	Education
IMA (Army)	19-24, unmarried male	Recognised university degree
INA (Navy)	19-24, unmarried male	Engineering degree; or BSc with Physics, plus Physics and Maths at Class 12
AFA (Air Force)	20-24; relaxable to 26 with a valid DGCA CPL	Degree with Physics and Maths at Class 12; or BE/B.Tech
OTA (SSC, men)	19-25, unmarried male	Recognised university degree
OTA (SSC, women)	19-25; unmarried women, issueless widows and divorcees who have not remarried	Recognised university degree

Two rules catch people out. First, the date of birth is accepted only from the Matriculation certificate. Second, male divorcees and widowers cannot be treated as 'unmarried' for IMA, INA, AFA or OTA. Air Force Academy candidates must also put AFA as their first choice, because they have to be

administered the Computer Pilot Selection System and Air Force medicals.

The CDS exam pattern

Paper	IMA / INA / AFA	OTA	Duration
English	100 marks	100 marks	2 hours
General Knowledge	100 marks	100 marks	2 hours
Elementary Mathematics	100 marks	Not required	2 hours
Written total	300 marks	200 marks	
SSB Interview	300 marks	200 marks	5 days

All papers are objective with 1/3 negative marking for a wrong answer and no penalty for a blank. Elementary Mathematics is set at the matriculation (Class 10) level - Arithmetic, Algebra, Trigonometry, Geometry, Mensuration and Statistics. English and General Knowledge are roughly graduate level. Calculators are not permitted. You must qualify in each paper as well as in the aggregate.

The written exam fee is Rs. 200, with female, SC and ST candidates exempt.

General Knowledge - where the marks sit

The GK paper rewards breadth. A recent paper's rough topic distribution looked like this - useful for deciding where to spend your revision hours:

Science	History	Geography	Polity	Armed Forces / Misc	Economy	Ecology
27	19	22	20	15	11	6

Science and geography together are nearly half the paper. History and polity together are another third. Build your GK from NCERTs (Classes 6-12 for history and geography) and a current-affairs habit, and treat defence-related awareness - exercises, acquisitions, appointments - as a distinct, high-yield topic.

PART 4

AFCAT 2027: the Air Force route

AFCAT - the Air Force Common Admission Test - is the Indian Air Force's own entrance exam for graduates. It is not conducted by UPSC. It runs twice a year and leads to the Flying branch and the Ground Duty (Technical and Non-Technical) branches.

The dates to watch

As of October 2026 the AFCAT 01/2027 notification has not been issued. Recent cycles give a reliable pattern: the 01 cycle opens applications in November-December and holds the exam in late January or February. So expect the notification in early November 2026 and the exam in late January 2027 - but confirm on the official portal, because these are projections, not announced dates.

Cycle	Applications	Exam	Course begins
AFCAT 01/2025	Dec 2024	Feb 2025	Jan 2026
AFCAT 01/2026	Nov-Dec 2025	31 Jan 2026	Jan 2027
AFCAT 02/2026	May-Jun 2026	8 Aug 2026	Jul 2027
AFCAT 01/2027	Expected Nov-Dec 2026	Expected late Jan 2027	Jan 2028 (if pattern holds)

The portal has moved

AFCAT applications are now made through the current official AFCAT portal. Older links and the former CDAC address no longer serve applications. Always start from the Indian Air Force's own careers website and follow its link to the AFCAT portal, so you never land on a look-alike site.

Eligibility by branch

Branch	Age at course start	Education
Flying	20-24; up to 26 with a valid CPL	Graduate (3 yr, any discipline) with 60%, plus 50% each in Maths and Physics at 10+2; or BE/B.Tech
Ground Duty (Technical)	20-26	Four-year engineering / technology degree (60%) in a notified stream
Ground Duty (Non-Technical)	20-26	Graduate (60%); specified graduation / post-graduation for Accounts, Education and Weapon Systems

Candidates below 25 must be unmarried, and marriage during training is not permitted. There is no category-based age relaxation in AFCAT - only the Commercial Pilot Licence relaxation applies, and only to the Flying branch. Final-year students may apply if they have no backlog and meet the marks requirement. The examination fee is Rs. 550 plus GST.

The AFCAT exam pattern

Feature	Detail
Mode	Online (computer-based)
Questions	100
Marks	300
Duration	2 hours
Marking	+3 for correct, -1 for wrong
Sections	General Awareness; Verbal Ability in English; Numerical Ability; Reasoning and Military Aptitude
EKT (Technical branch only)	50 questions, 150 marks, 45 minutes

The +3 / -1 marking is more forgiving than UPSC's one-third penalty, but a careless guess still costs you. The EKT - the Engineering Knowledge Test - is sat only by candidates applying to the Technical branch, immediately after the main AFCAT paper.

After the written stage, successful candidates go to an Air Force Selection Board (AFSB). The AFSB is the Air Force's version of the SSB: the same five-day structure, the same psychologist-GTO-interviewing-officer trio, and the same 15 Officer-Like Qualities. Everything in Parts 5 and 6 applies to you.

PART 5

The SSB Interview: the five days that decide everything

The Services Selection Board is not a test of knowledge. It is a five-day assessment of who you are. Three independent assessors watch you from three different angles and only compare notes at the very end. Understanding the structure removes most of the fear.

What the SSB is really measuring

The SSB looks for Officer-Like Qualities - leadership, courage, responsibility, teamwork, decision-making and stamina. It does not score 'correct answers'. It reads patterns in your thoughts, your speech and your actions. Three assessors build an independent picture of you:

The Psychologist reads your subconscious through written tests. **The Group Testing Officer (GTO)** watches you in action in group tasks. **The Interviewing Officer (IO)** questions you face to face. Their three views are combined at the conference on the final day.

The structure of the five days

Day	Stage	What happens
Reporting (Day 0)	Arrival	Document check, chest number, Personal Information Questionnaire (PIQ)
Day 1	Screening	OIR test and PPDT; results the same day. Many candidates are screened out here
Day 2	Psychology	TAT, WAT, SRT and Self-Description, all written under strict time limits
Days 3-4	GTO tasks	Group discussion, planning exercise, obstacle tasks, lecturette; personal interview
Day 5	Conference	Brief appearance before the full board; result announced the same day

For the NDA the SSB carries 900 marks - as much as the entire written exam. For CDS IMA/INA/AFA it is 300 marks, and 200 for OTA. The weight tells you where the selection is really won.

Day 0 and Day 1: reporting and screening

You report the evening before Day 1. You are given a chest number and asked to fill the Personal Information Questionnaire - the PIQ. Treat the PIQ as the most important form you will ever fill: everything you write on it becomes material for your interview, and inconsistencies between the PIQ, your psychological tests and your interview are noticed.

The OIR test

The Officer Intelligence Rating test is two papers of verbal and non-verbal reasoning, roughly 40 questions each in about 17 minutes per paper. It is not about knowledge - it is about speed and accuracy. Practice reasoning tests beforehand.

The PPDT

The Picture Perception and Discussion Test shows you a hazy picture for about 30 seconds. You then write a short story in about four minutes - with a hero, a clear situation and a positive outcome - and afterwards discuss it in a group to arrive at a common story. Assessors watch for initiative, clear communication and how you behave in a group. This day alone screens out a large share of candidates, so it is not a formality.

Day 2: the psychology tests

Four projective tests, all written, all timed. None has a 'right answer' - the psychologist is reading for consistent, natural officer-like qualities across everything you write.

Test	What you do
TAT - Thematic Apperception Test	Write a story for each of about 11-12 pictures (the last is blank) in a few minutes each
WAT - Word Association Test	60 words are flashed, one at a time; write the first sentence that comes to mind for each
SRT - Situation Reaction Test	Around 60 everyday situations; write a brief, practical response to each
SD - Self-Description	Describe how your parents, teachers, friends, and you yourself would see you

Keep your stories realistic and positive, give your hero initiative and responsibility rather than luck, and stay consistent with what you wrote in your PIQ. Fabricated or over-dramatic answers stand out to a trained psychologist.

Days 3 and 4: the GTO tasks

The Group Testing Officer runs indoor and outdoor tasks that reveal how you behave in a group. No leader is appointed - the GTO watches who naturally contributes, cooperates and leads without dominating.

Task	What it tests
Group Discussion (GD)	Two rounds - a current-affairs topic and a general topic; clarity and listening
Group Planning Exercise (GPE)	A model terrain with a complex scenario; the group plans and presents one solution
Progressive Group Task (PGT)	Crossing outdoor obstacles with limited resources (plank, rope); teamwork and rules
Group Obstacle Race (Snake Race)	A competitive group obstacle race; team spirit under pressure
Half Group Task (HGT)	Same format as the PGT with half the group, so each person is more visible
Lecturette	A short impromptu talk (about 3 minutes) on a topic of your choice from a given list
Individual Obstacles (IO)	Ten obstacles of increasing difficulty, each worth points; fitness matters
Command Task	You command 2-3 subordinates to solve an obstacle; leadership, briefing and planning
Final Group Task (FGT)	One last group obstacle task; confirms the GTO's impressions

The personal interview with the Interviewing Officer usually runs somewhere between Day 2 and Day 4, lasts 45 to 60 minutes, and covers your PIQ, your background, your hobbies, current affairs and your motivation for joining. There is no trick to it: the interview rewards a candidate who genuinely knows himself and the world around him.

Day 5: the conference and the result

On the final day you appear briefly before the full board - the IO, the GTO, the psychologist and the President or Deputy President. It is a few questions and an overall impression check. Then the board discusses each candidate across all three assessment streams and announces the recommended candidates the same day. Recommended candidates stay for the medical examination, which itself takes several days.

Where the SSB is held

Boards are allotted based on the entry and your preference. The Army uses Selection Centres, the Air Force uses Air Force Selection Boards, and the Navy uses Naval Selection Boards.

Service	Selection centres / boards
Indian Army	Selection Centre East (Prayagraj), Selection Centre Central (Bhopal), Selection Centre South (Bengaluru), Selection Centre North (Kapurthala)
Indian Air Force	1 AFSB Dehradun, 2 AFSB Mysuru, 3 AFSB Gandhinagar, 4 AFSB Varanasi, 5 AFSB Guwahati
Indian Navy	Naval Selection Boards at Bhopal, Bengaluru, Coimbatore, Visakhapatnam and Kolkata

The medical, and the wait

Recommended candidates go straight into a medical examination lasting around four to five days at a military hospital. Air Force and Navy aspirants face additional flying and eyesight standards. Even after a medical, the final merit list depends on your combined written and SSB marks. The whole process, from written exam to joining, can take many months - plan your year around it.

PART 6

The 15 Officer-Like Qualities, and how each is tested

Everything the SSB does is aimed at one thing: detecting 15 Officer-Like Qualities (OLQs). They are grouped into four factors. Once you know the list, the whole five days stop looking random.

Factor	Quality	How it is tested
I. Planning and Organising	Effective Intelligence	OIR test; the quality of ideas in group tasks
	Reasoning Ability	OIR; reasoning in the GPE and discussion
	Organising Ability	How you marshal resources and people in PGT, HGT and Command Task
	Power of Expression	PPDT narration, GD, lecturette, interview
II. Social Adjustment	Social Adaptability	How you blend into the group in GD and outdoor tasks
	Cooperation	Teamwork in PGT, Snake Race and FGT
	Sense of Responsibility	Whether you take ownership in SRT and group tasks
III. Social Effectiveness	Initiative	Whether you start things in the group without being asked
	Self Confidence	Lecturette, interview and individual obstacles
	Speed of Decision	How quickly and sensibly you respond in SRT and outdoor tasks
	Ability to Influence the Group	Whether your ideas carry weight in the GD and GPE
	Liveliness	Your energy and natural manner across the five days
IV. Dynamic	Determination	Persistence on hard obstacles and long days
	Courage	Individual obstacles, command task, willingness to take a stand
	Stamina	Physical tasks across the whole process

Some of these qualities are more trainable than others. Effective intelligence, social adaptability, cooperation, sense of responsibility, liveliness and determination are the ones usually described as harder to change quickly. The rest - organising ability, power of expression, initiative, self-confidence, speed of decision, influence, courage and stamina - respond well to deliberate practice. That is where the next several months of your effort should go.

A practical way to build OLQs

Play a team sport. Take responsibility in a club, a society or a college event. Speak up in groups and learn to disagree politely. Read a newspaper daily and form opinions on it. Take on a physical fitness routine and stick to it. None of this is exam preparation - and all of it is SSB preparation, because the SSB is reading the person these habits build.

PART 7

The SSB practice bank

Knowledge of the SSB structure is not the same as being ready for it. The tests reward fast, natural, positive responses - and speed comes from practice. This bank gives you a realistic starting set for each test. Do not memorise the sample answers; use them to see the shape of a good response, then write your own, in your own words, until the habit is automatic.

One rule for all four psychology tests

Stay consistent. The psychologist compares what you write in the WAT, SRT and Self-Description with your PIQ and with what you say in the interview. A positive, practical, own-your-action tone that runs through everything you write is what the board is looking for - not dramatic or borrowed answers.

Word Association Test - 50 words with a sample response

For each word, write the first meaningful sentence that comes to mind. Keep it short, positive and action-oriented. The samples below show the tone; your sentences should be your own.

Word	Sample response
Duty	A soldier's first duty is to the nation and his team.
Fear	Fear is overcome by preparation and a calm mind.
Leader	A leader takes responsibility and leads from the front.
Failure	Failure teaches the lesson that success needs.
Friend	A true friend stands by you in difficult times.
Mother	A mother's sacrifice shapes a person's character.
Night	Night gives rest so the day's work can be done well.
Fire	Fire must be handled with care and quick action.
River	A river keeps moving and finds its way to the sea.
Team	A strong team achieves what one person cannot.
Discipline	Discipline is the foundation of every achievement.
Country	Every citizen should work for the country's progress.
War	War should be avoided, but a nation must be ready to defend itself.
Speed	Speed with accuracy wins the race.
Blood	Blood donation can save a life in an emergency.
Mountain	Climbing a mountain needs stamina and determination.
Command	A good commander plans well and cares for his men.
Death	A brave soldier faces death for a cause greater than himself.
Enemy	A wise soldier understands the enemy before acting.
Success	Success comes from steady effort and honesty.
Alone	Working alone builds self-reliance.
Help	Helping others strengthens a team.
Anger	Anger must be controlled with patience.

Word	Sample response
Training	Training turns effort into ability.
Responsibility	A responsible person owns his task till the end.
Water	Clean water is essential for health.
Victory	Victory belongs to the team that prepares best.
Silence	Silence helps a leader think clearly.
Weapon	A weapon is safe only in trained hands.
Flag	The flag stands for the nation's honour.
Courage	Courage is doing the right thing despite fear.
Family	A strong family supports every ambition.
Money	Money should be earned honestly and used wisely.
Time	Time used well is a person's greatest asset.
Problem	Every problem has a solution for a calm mind.
Officer	An officer leads by example.
Health	Good health is the base of every effort.
Book	Books give the knowledge that experience alone cannot.
Path	Choosing the right path needs clear thinking.
Storm	A storm tests the strength of a good ship.
Sacrifice	Sacrifice for the team builds lasting trust.
Order	A clear order prevents confusion in action.
Boy	A disciplined boy grows into a responsible man.
Sea	The sea rewards those who respect it.
Risk	A calculated risk is better than no decision.
Example	A good example teaches more than advice.
Hope	Hope keeps a person working through hard times.
Nation	Every soldier serves the nation before himself.
Aim	A clear aim keeps effort focused.
Future	The future is built by what we do today.

Situation Reaction Test - 30 situations with a sample response

Read each situation and write what you would actually do, in one or two lines. Show initiative, responsibility and a practical, mature reaction.

Situation	Sample response
He was returning home late and saw a road accident.	He stopped, called the ambulance and helped the injured until help arrived.
His friend borrowed money and did not return it.	He spoke to the friend calmly and set a clear date to repay.
He was in a train when a fire broke out in a coach.	He alerted the passengers, used the alarm and helped people exit.
He found a wallet on the road with cash and cards.	He handed it to the nearest police station and informed the owner.
His team lost an important match.	He encouraged the team and analysed the mistakes to improve.
He was asked to lead a group he had never met.	He introduced himself, understood each member's strength and set a plan.
He failed an exam he had prepared hard for.	He reviewed his mistakes and prepared again with a better plan.
He saw a boy drowning in a pond.	He raised an alarm and helped pull the boy out safely.
His senior gave him a task he did not know.	He asked for clarity, learned the basics and completed it.
He was blamed for a mistake he did not make.	He stayed calm, explained the facts and helped fix the problem.
There was no electricity during an exam.	He informed the authorities and continued with the available light.
He found his colleague cheating.	He advised the colleague against it and reported the matter.
He was late for an interview due to traffic.	He informed the office, arrived calmly and explained the delay.
His father fell ill suddenly.	He arranged medical help and informed the family.
He had to cross a flooded road.	He found a safe route or waited rather than taking a needless risk.
He was posted far from home.	He accepted it, stayed in touch with family and focused on duty.
A stranger asked him for directions in an unknown area.	He helped as best he could and pointed him to someone reliable.
He was given an impossible deadline.	He prioritised the key tasks and informed his seniors early.
He saw a group teasing a weaker student.	He intervened, stopped it and supported the student.
His bike broke down on a highway.	He pushed it to safety and arranged help.
He was offered a shortcut that was wrong.	He refused and followed the correct route.
He had to choose between two equally good offers.	He weighed long-term growth and decided.
He was asked a question he could not answer.	He admitted it honestly and promised to find out.
He saw a fire in a neighbour's kitchen.	He alerted the family and helped put it out safely.
He lost his wallet during travel.	He blocked the cards, informed the bank and filed a report.
His group was arguing over a plan.	He listened to both sides and suggested a common solution.
He was the youngest in a senior meeting.	He listened, then contributed a clear point when it mattered.
He was asked to do an unfair task.	He raised the concern politely through the right channel.
He found a lost child in a market.	He stayed with the child and handed him to security.

Situation	Sample response
He had to prepare for an exam and a family function together.	He planned his time so neither suffered.

TAT - the four-part story frame

For each picture, write a story in four parts. Keep it realistic, give the hero initiative and responsibility, and end on a positive, practical outcome. The last slide in the test is blank - write a story about something you would genuinely like to achieve.

- 1 Who is in the picture, and what is the situation?
- 2 What is the problem or the challenge?
- 3 What does the hero do about it - specifically?
- 4 How does it end, and what does the hero learn or achieve?

Fifteen themes to practise with (describe your own picture in words, then write the story):

- A young man helping villagers during a flood.
- A group of students planning a community clean-up.
- A soldier guiding a lost child back to safety.
- A boy training hard for a race despite a setback.
- A team working together to repair a broken bridge.
- A young woman teaching children in a village.
- A person helping an accident victim on a highway.
- A student organising a blood-donation camp.
- A farmer using a new method to save his crop.
- A group rescuing a trapped animal.
- A candidate leading his team in a difficult task.
- A person returning lost property to its owner.
- A youth motivating his friends against a bad habit.
- A mountaineer helping a struggling teammate.
- A blank slide - your own goal, and the path to it.

Lecturette - 30 topics to rehearse

Pick a topic, think for one minute, and speak for about three minutes. Record yourself if you can. Aim for a clear opening, three points and a short conclusion.

- My role model · The importance of discipline · India's youth and the future
- Social media: a boon or a bane · Women in the armed forces · Terrorism and its causes
- The value of teamwork · My hometown · National integration
- India's space programme · Corruption and the common citizen · The importance of fitness
- My favourite book · Digital India · Climate change and India
- The Indian Army · What makes a good leader · Education in rural India
- A memorable incident in my life · The Constitution of India · Sports and character

- Self-reliance · Unemployment and skills · My duty towards the nation
- My ambition · Technology in modern defence · India-Pakistan relations
- The importance of honesty · My school life · The benefits of yoga

Personal interview - 40 questions to prepare for

These are drawn from the kinds of questions asked across boards. Do not script answers; know your own story so well that you can answer any of them naturally. Every answer should be consistent with your PIQ.

- Tell me about yourself.
- Why do you want to join the armed forces?
- What do your parents do?
- Describe your daily routine.
- What are your strengths and weaknesses?
- Who is your role model, and why?
- Which was your best subject, and why?
- Tell me about your best friend.
- How do you spend your free time?
- What did you do in your last summer vacation?
- Which newspaper do you read, and why?
- What is the latest defence news you followed?
- If you are not selected this time, what will you do?
- What is your biggest achievement?
- What is your biggest failure, and what did you learn from it?
- How do you handle stress?
- Name a leader you admire, and why.
- What is the difference between the Army, Navy and Air Force?
- Why did you choose your particular wing?
- What does courage mean to you?
- Tell me about your family.
- What are your hobbies?
- Have you ever led a team? Describe it.
- What is teamwork?
- What do you understand by the SSB?
- What is your hometown famous for?
- Which book changed your thinking?
- What does discipline mean to you?
- Where do you see yourself ten years from now?
- What would you do if a senior broke a rule?

- How do you handle criticism?
- Why is physical fitness important for an officer?
- Tell me about a time you helped someone.
- What is the role of youth in nation building?
- What does the uniform mean to you?
- What is your favourite sport, and why?
- What is your plan for the next five years?
- Why should we select you?
- What will you do if you are posted in a remote area?
- Do you have any questions for us?

OIR practice set - 15 questions with answers

The Officer Intelligence Rating test is speed reasoning, not knowledge. Work through this set without a calculator and check your answers. Then practise full OIR papers under a timer.

Question	Answer
Which number comes next: 2, 6, 12, 20, 30, ___ ?	42 (the pattern is $n \times (n+1)$)
Odd one out: Apple, Banana, Carrot, Mango	Carrot (the others are fruits)
If CAT = 3-1-20, then DOG = ?	4-15-7 (letter positions)
Which letter comes next: A, C, F, J, O, ___ ?	U (+2, +3, +4, +5, +6)
Analogy: Book is to Read as Food is to ___	Eat
Which number comes next: 5, 11, 23, 47, ___ ?	95 ($\times 2$, then $+1$)
Odd one out: 3, 5, 7, 9, 11	9 (not a prime number)
If MONDAY is coded NPOEBZ, then FRIDAY is ___	GSJEBZ (each letter $+1$)
Which letter comes next: Z, X, V, T, ___ ?	R (-2 each step)
Analogy: Doctor is to Hospital as Teacher is to ___	School
Which number comes next: 1, 4, 9, 16, 25, ___ ?	36 (perfect squares)
Which does not belong: Circle, Square, Triangle, Cube	Cube (the others are flat shapes)
A man said, 'He is the son of my father's only son.' Who is he?	His own son
Which number comes next: 2, 3, 5, 7, 11, ___ ?	13 (prime numbers)
If A=1, B=2 and so on, what is the sum of the letters in CAB?	6 ($3 + 1 + 2$)

How to practise this bank

Week 1: read the WAT and SRT samples and write your own for all of them. Week 2: do the TAT themes and record three lecturettes. Week 3: run the interview questions with a friend, out loud. Week 4: time yourself on the OIR set. By the time your call-up letter arrives, none of the five days will be a surprise.

PART 8

Preparation playbooks

Three short, concrete playbooks. Use the one that matches your exam, and remember that the GAT/GK habits help the CDS and AFCAT as well.

Mathematics (NDA Paper I)

- 1 Build the base first. Spend the first three weeks on algebra, trigonometry and calculus fundamentals from your Class 11-12 NCERT textbooks. Do not touch mock papers yet.
- 2 Then practise topic by topic. Twenty questions per topic, timed. Keep an error log - a notebook where every wrong answer is written down with the reason it went wrong.
- 3 Learn the negative-marking discipline. In practice, leave a question blank the moment you are not reasonably sure. Your mock score should reflect the same discipline you will use on exam day.
- 4 Move to full 120-question papers only in the last six weeks. Two a week, always with a timer and an OMR sheet.

GAT and GK - the marks that decide most results

- 1 Read one English newspaper daily and note ten new words a week. English is the easier 200 marks; bank them.
- 2 For General Knowledge, work through NCERTs for Physics, Chemistry, Biology, History and Geography at the level UPSC sets - mostly Class 6 to 12.
- 3 Keep a single running current-affairs notebook, updated weekly, with separate pages for national, international and defence news.
- 4 Do not chase obscure facts. The GAT rewards breadth and confidence, not trivia.

CDS-specific adjustments

- If you are sitting for OTA, drop Maths entirely and put those hours into English and GK.
- Elementary Mathematics is Class 10 level - so your enemy is speed, not difficulty. Drill arithmetic and mensuration until they are automatic.
- Graduate-level English and GK need a wider net than the NDA: read editorials, and follow Indian polity and economy as current subjects, not just as history.

AFCAT-specific adjustments

- AFCAT rewards speed. Practise 100 questions in 120 minutes until it feels routine.
- Numerical Ability in AFCAT is easier than NDA Maths but tighter on time - practise mental arithmetic.
- Reasoning and Military Aptitude rewards pattern recognition; practise series, analogies and spatial reasoning.
- If you are applying for the Technical branch, add the EKT (50 questions, 45 minutes) to your plan.

PART 9

The 90-day plan: October 2026 to April 2027

The NDA and CDS written exams fall on 11 April 2027. That gives a candidate starting today about six months. This plan front-loads the base-building and reserves the final weeks for mocks and revision.

Phase 1 - Build the base (October to December 2026)

- Complete NCERTs for Maths, Physics, Chemistry, Biology, History and Geography, one chapter a day.
- Start a current-affairs notebook and update it every week.
- Read 30 minutes of English daily and note new words.
- Begin a physical routine: running, push-ups, and a team sport. Your SSB body starts here.
- Submit your application the day the window opens - do not wait for the last date.

Phase 2 - Sharpen the paper (January to February 2027)

- Move to topic-wise practice and start your error log.
- Begin two sectional tests a week, timed, with negative marking applied honestly.
- Take one full-length mock every fortnight.
- Keep the current-affairs notebook and physical routine going.

Phase 3 - Peak and taper (March to 11 April 2027)

- Two full-length mocks a week, always under exam conditions.
- Revise your error log, not new material, in the final three weeks.
- In the last ten days, reduce volume and protect sleep. Arrive at the exam fresh, not exhausted.
- Re-read your application details so nothing surprises you on the admit card.

The SSB thread that runs through all of it

Do not leave SSB preparation to the weeks after the written result. From October onward, build the habits the SSB reads: a team sport, a responsibility you own, opinions on the news, and physical fitness. By the time your SSB call-up arrives, the person in the room will already be the person the board is looking for.

PART 10

The application walkthrough and the 12 rejection traps

For UPSC exams, the application is now a two-step process built on One Time Registration (OTR). Getting it wrong can cost you an attempt you cannot get back.

The UPSC application, step by step

- 1 Complete One Time Registration (OTR) on the UPSC online portal. This creates your Universal Registration Number and a permanent profile with your photo, signature and ID.
- 2 When the notification opens, log in, choose the exam, and fill the Examination Specific Module - including your fee and centre preferences.
- 3 Upload a live photo captured on the website or the UPSC app where required - pre-scanned photos are not accepted for some modules.
- 4 Pay the fee online (net banking, card or UPI) if you are not exempt, and download the confirmation.
- 5 Note your registration number and keep the confirmation safe for the admit card stage.

The 12 traps that cost candidates a year

- 1 Missing the OTR step and trying to apply without it.
- 2 A date of birth that does not match the Class 10 certificate.
- 3 A fee category claimed wrongly - OBC and EWS do not get the fee exemption that SC, ST and female candidates get.
- 4 Waiting for the final day: the portal slows under load and a crashed submission means a lost attempt.
- 5 Choosing a wing or academy you are not educationally eligible for.
- 6 Forgetting that a married candidate cannot apply to the NDA, or as an unmarried male to CDS IMA/INA/AFA.
- 7 Uploading a photo or signature that does not meet the specification.
- 8 Leaving the AFA first-choice rule unmet in CDS, which invalidates the Air Force choice.
- 9 Not reading the notification's own eligibility list because you relied on a coaching blog.
- 10 Mistyping the email or mobile number that all future communication depends on.
- 11 Paying a 'facilitator' to fill your form - no one else can, and no one else should.
- 12 Assuming an exam centre and date can be changed after allotment. In AFCAT, they cannot.

Keep these documents ready before the window opens

Class 10 (Matriculation) certificate - the only accepted proof of date of birth. Class 12 marksheet/certificate. Degree certificate or final-year proof (CDS/AFCAT). A valid photo ID. A recent photograph and signature meeting the specification. NCC 'C' certificate, if you have one, for the relevant entries. Category certificate, where applicable.

PART 11

Pay, training and life after selection

It helps to know what you are working for. The pay is set by the 7th Central Pay Commission and is only part of the story - a service career brings accommodation, medical cover for your family, and early responsibility.

What a cadet and a young officer earn

Stage / Rank	Pay
Cadet stipend during training at the academy	Rs. 56,100 per month (starting pay in Level 10)
On commissioning - Lieutenant	Level 10: Rs. 56,100 to Rs. 1,77,500
Military Service Pay (MSP)	Rs. 15,500 per month fixed, for Lieutenant to Brigadier

The MSP is paid on top of basic pay and, along with Dearness Allowance and other allowances, forms part of the monthly package. The rank-wise progression runs from Lieutenant up through Captain, Major, Lieutenant Colonel, Colonel and beyond, with the Chief of Army Staff's pay fixed at the top of the structure.

The training path

- NDA cadets train for three years at Khadakwasla, Pune, alongside academic study, and then go on to their service academy.
- IMA cadets train for roughly 18 months at Dehradun.
- Air Force cadets pass through the Air Force Academy at Hyderabad.
- OTA cadets train for about 49 weeks at Chennai for a short service commission.
- Cadets receive a stipend throughout, and the training period is not counted as commissioned service.

The life behind the pay

An officer's life is not a desk job. It means postings across the country, early command of people, and a career built on responsibility rather than seniority alone. That is precisely why the SSB measures character and not marks. If the career appeals to you for those reasons, the preparation stops being a grind and becomes the start of something.

PART 12

Scams, myths and red flags

Defence aspirants are a large, motivated audience, which makes them a target. Here is what to watch for, and the myths that quietly cost people attempts.

Red flags - walk away

- Anyone promising a 'guaranteed' selection, a 'recommendation' at the SSB, or a 'contact' in the board. Selection is decided by the board, not by outsiders.
- Anyone offering to fill your application for a fee. The form is yours and only yours to submit.
- Sellers of 'leaked' papers or 'advance' question banks. Real question papers are not available before the exam, and buying a fake can end your candidature.
- Portals that look like the official UPSC or AFCAT site but are not. Type the official address yourself; do not follow links from messages.
- Payment requests on unofficial numbers for 'registration' or 'SSB coaching guarantee'.

Myths to drop

The myth	The reality
'You need coaching to clear the written exam.'	Self-study from NCERTs and a disciplined mock routine clears the written stage for many candidates.
'The SSB is a lottery.'	It is a structured, three-assessor assessment of the 15 OLQs. It is hard, not random.
'English fluency decides the SSB.'	Clarity of thought and sincerity matter more than accent or fluency.
'You can only attempt once.'	There is no limit on CDS attempts within the age and eligibility rules; the NDA window is set by your birth date.
'Physical fitness does not matter for the written stage.'	It matters at the SSB and the medical, and you should be building it from day one.

PART 13

Frequently asked questions

Q. Can girls apply for the NDA?

Yes. Following the Supreme Court's 2021 order, unmarried women are eligible on the same terms as men. In each 2026 cycle, 24 of 394 seats were for women.

Q. What is the age limit for the NDA?

UPSC sets a birth-date window, not a range. The NDA (II) 2026 window was born between 1 January 2008 and 1 January 2011, roughly 16.5 to 19.5 years. The NDA (I) 2027 window is published with the notification on 2 December 2026.

Q. Can a married candidate apply?

No for the NDA. For CDS, IMA/INA/AFA require unmarried male candidates; OTA women may include issueless widows and divorcees who have not remarried.

Q. What is the NDA exam fee?

Rs. 100. Female, SC and ST candidates are exempt, as are certain wards of service personnel. OBC and EWS candidates pay.

Q. How many marks is the NDA written exam?

900 - Mathematics 300 and the General Ability Test 600. The SSB adds another 900, for a total of 1800.

Q. Is there negative marking?

Yes. One-third of a question's marks is deducted for a wrong answer in both NDA papers, in CDS, and in AFCAT (which uses +3 / -1). Blank answers are not penalised.

Q. Which is more important, the Maths paper or the GAT?

The GAT, by weight. It carries 600 of the 900 written marks, and its General Knowledge section alone is 400 marks - more than the whole Maths paper.

Q. Does the CDS OTA paper have Maths?

No. OTA candidates sit only English and General Knowledge, for 200 marks. IMA, INA and AFA candidates also sit Elementary Mathematics.

Q. Can final-year students apply for the CDS?

Yes, subject to the notification's conditions, including producing degree proof by the specified date.

Q. What is the CDS exam fee?

Rs. 200, with female, SC and ST candidates exempt.

Q. Is AFCAT conducted by UPSC?

No. AFCAT is conducted by the Indian Air Force. It runs twice a year and is followed by an Air Force Selection Board.

Q. What is the AFCAT marking scheme?

100 questions, 300 marks, 2 hours, with +3 for a correct answer and -1 for a wrong one. Technical-branch candidates also sit the EKT.

Q. How long is the SSB?

Five testing days after the reporting day, plus a medical examination for recommended candidates.

Q. Who assesses me at the SSB?

Three people independently: a Psychologist, a Group Testing Officer, and an Interviewing Officer. They combine their views at the final conference.

Q. What are the 15 OLQs?

The Officer-Like Qualities grouped into four factors: Planning and Organising (4), Social Adjustment (3), Social Effectiveness (5) and Dynamic (3). Part 6 lists all 15 with how each is tested.

Q. Can I prepare for the SSB, or is it innate?

Much of it is trainable. Initiative, self-confidence, organising ability, power of expression and stamina all respond to deliberate practice.

Q. Where will my SSB be held?

At one of the Selection Centres (Prayagraj, Bhopal, Bengaluru, Kapurthala for the Army), Air Force Selection Boards (Dehradun, Mysuru, Gandhinagar, Varanasi, Guwahati), or Naval Selection Boards (Bhopal, Bengaluru, Coimbatore, Visakhapatnam, Kolkata).

Q. What does a cadet earn during training?

A stipend of Rs. 56,100 per month, the starting pay in Level 10.

Q. Is there a limit on attempts?

There is no attempt limit for the CDS within the age and eligibility rules. The NDA window is set by your birth date, so the number of cycles you can sit is finite.

Q. Where do I confirm the dates?

On the official UPSC website for NDA and CDS, and on the Indian Air Force's AFCAT portal for AFCAT. Always use the official notification for your own cycle.

APPENDIX A

Document checklist

Item	NDA	CDS	AFCAT
Class 10 (Matriculation) certificate	Yes	Yes	Yes
Class 12 marksheet / certificate	Yes	Yes	Yes
Degree certificate / final-year proof	-	Yes	Yes
Valid photo ID	Yes	Yes	Yes
Photograph and signature (as specified)	Yes	Yes	Yes
Category certificate (if applicable)	Yes	Yes	Yes
NCC 'C' certificate (for NCC entry)	If applicable	If applicable	NCC entry only

APPENDIX B

90-day tracker (photocopy or redraw)

Week	Maths target	GK / English target	Mock / test	Fitness	Done
1-2	Algebra base	NCERT Physics Ch. 1-4; 20 new words	-	Run 3x	
3-4	Trigonometry base	NCERT Chemistry Ch. 1-4; 20 words	1 sectional	Run 3x	
5-6	Calculus base	History + Geography chapters	1 sectional	Sport	
7-8	Matrices, vectors	Biology + current affairs review	1 full mock	Sport	
9-10	Statistics, probability	Polity + economy basics	2 sectionals	Sport	
11-12	Revision + error log	Defence current affairs	1 full mock	Sport	
13+	Full papers	Revision only	2 full mocks/week	Maintain	

APPENDIX C

Glossary of terms you will meet

Term	Meaning
NDA & NA	National Defence Academy and Naval Academy Examination, conducted by UPSC
CDS	Combined Defence Services Examination, conducted by UPSC
AFCAT	Air Force Common Admission Test, conducted by the Indian Air Force
SSB	Services Selection Board - the five-day personality assessment
AFSB	Air Force Selection Board
OLQ	Officer-Like Quality - one of the 15 traits the SSB assesses
OIR	Officer Intelligence Rating test, on the first screening day
PPDT	Picture Perception and Discussion Test
TAT / WAT / SRT / SD	The four psychology tests: Thematic Apperception, Word Association, Situation Reaction, Self-Description

Term	Meaning
GTO	Group Testing Officer, who runs the outdoor and group tasks
IO	Interviewing Officer, who conducts the personal interview
GPE / PGT / HGT / FGT	Group Planning Exercise, Progressive Group Task, Half Group Task, Final Group Task
PIQ	Personal Information Questionnaire, filled at the SSB
CPL	Commercial Pilot Licence, which relaxes the age limit for the Air Force Flying branch
IMA / INA / AFA / OTA	Indian Military Academy, Indian Naval Academy, Air Force Academy, Officers' Training Academy
EKT	Engineering Knowledge Test, for AFCAT Technical branch candidates
MSP	Military Service Pay, a fixed monthly allowance for officers

APPENDIX D

Mathematics formula sheet (NDA and CDS)

Topic	Formula
Quadratic equation $ax^2 + bx + c = 0$	Roots = $(-b \pm \sqrt{b^2 - 4ac}) / 2a$
Arithmetic progression	n th term = $a + (n-1)d$; Sum = $(n/2)(2a + (n-1)d)$
Geometric progression	n th term = $a r^{n-1}$; Sum = $a(r^n - 1) / (r - 1)$
Trigonometric identities	$\sin^2 x + \cos^2 x = 1$; $1 + \tan^2 x = \sec^2 x$; $1 + \cot^2 x = \operatorname{cosec}^2 x$
Double angle	$\sin 2x = 2 \sin x \cos x$; $\cos 2x = \cos^2 x - \sin^2 x$
Circle	Area = πr^2 ; Circumference = $2 \pi r$
Mensuration (solids)	Sphere $4/3 \pi r^3$; Cylinder $\pi r^2 h$; Cone $1/3 \pi r^2 h$
Triangle (Heron)	Area = $\sqrt{s(s-a)(s-b)(s-c)}$, where $s = (a+b+c)/2$
Speed, distance, time	Distance = Speed $\times$ Time; Speed = Distance / Time
Simple and compound interest	SI = $P R T / 100$; CI = $P(1 + R/100)^n - P$
Statistics	Mean = (sum of x)/ n ; SD = $\sqrt{\text{sum of } (x - \text{mean})^2 / n}$
Probability	$P(E)$ = number of favourable outcomes / total outcomes

APPENDIX E

General Knowledge rapid-revision sheet

Category	High-yield fact
Supreme Commander	The President of India is the Supreme Commander of the Armed Forces
Academies	NDA Khadakwasla (Pune); IMA Dehradun; INA Ezhimala; AFA Hyderabad; OTA Chennai
Gallantry awards	Param Vir Chakra - highest wartime; Ashoka Chakra - highest peacetime
Service days	Army Day 15 January; Navy Day 4 December; Air Force Day 8 October
Kargil	Kargil Vijay Diwas - 26 July; the 1999 operation was named Operation Vijay
Missiles	Agni - ballistic; BrahMos - supersonic cruise, developed with Russia

Category	High-yield fact
Key platforms	INS Vikrant - indigenous aircraft carrier; Tejas - light combat aircraft; Rafale - multirole fighter
CDS post	The Chief of Defence Staff post was created in 2019
Constitution	Fundamental duties are listed in Article 51A
Geography	Longest river in India - the Ganga; highest peak - Kangchenjunga

Before you close this book

Confirm every date and eligibility rule in your own cycle's official notification. Then do the one thing that separates aspirants who make it from those who do not: start today, not in January. Six months from now, on 11 April 2027, you will be glad you did.